

MAN OF THE PEOPLE
CM N. Rangasamy campaigning for candidate Vaiyapuri Manikandan in Muthialpet constituency, Puducherry, Mar. 30

ASSEMBLY POLLS | PUDUCHERRY

A FINE BALANCE

WITH STRAINED ALLIANCES ON BOTH SIDES IN PUDUCHERRY, THE NDA FACES OFF AGAINST THE CONGRESS-DMK, HOPING TO CAPITALISE ON CM N. RANGASAMY'S PERSONAL CONNECT WITH VOTERS

By **KAVITHA MURALIDHARAN**

Puducherry's relatively small 30-member assembly is not going to face the straight fight expected of it on April 9, when voters in the Union Territory face an unsteady triangle and candidates visibly disgruntled with seat-sharing arrangements. On one side is the National Democratic Alliance (NDA); on the other the Congress and Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK), and in between, the Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK), which may not have enough heft to be in the reckoning but can nibble away crucial votes from either side and ruin everyone's mood. In such a small territory, sweeping mandates are rare, so wins come down to hundreds of votes. With such fractious alliances in contest, victory will depend on whom voters trust to work together.

The NDA, led by chief minister N. Rangasamy's All India N.R. Congress (AINRC), is pinning much hope on the stalwart. His personal connect with voters obviating any electoral arithmetic, he has survived multiple political realignments for over three decades. Partnered with the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP), the All India Anna Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (AIADMK) and the green Latchiya Jananayaga Katchi (LJK) floated by a lottery baron's son, the alliance saw considerable noise due to the BJP's insistence on bringing in the LJK, which complicated an already fraught seat-sharing. The alliance held together in the end, but it took work, and the strains are not entirely invisible.